

KRISHNA MURARI KISHAN



NITISH KUMAR

Raising political temperatures in Bihar and making a revealing comment on the competence of the state police, murder charges against Chief Minister Nitish Kumar came back to momentarily haunt him last week—in what is an 18-year-old case. The case pertains to the murder of Congress supporter Sitaram Singh, who was killed on a polling day in Barh in 1991. Nitish went on to win the Barh seat against Congress candidate Sidhewar. While Nitish was given a clean chit in 1993, the police filed a chargesheet against three others. Sixteen years and an image makeover later, the Additional Chief Judicial Magistrate's (ACJM) court in Barh ordered summons to be issued against Nitish and Dularchand, another accused. The Patna High Court has stayed the summons against Nitish after hearing his lawyer. The High Court has also called for the case records from the lower court, said Bihar Advocate General P.K. Shahi. *by Amitabh Srivastava*

KOLKATA | Lotus Pocus

WEST BENGAL IS FACING A SHORTAGE OF TWO CRORE LOTUS FLOWERS FOR DURGA PUJA FESTIVITIES.

What does a devotee do when the supply of the most vital offering in prayer falls short? For the first time in the history of West Bengal's Durga Puja celebrations, organisers will have to look for alternatives to the lotus flower. The state needs at least two crore lotus flowers for the thousands of Puja

pandals, but floriculturists have said that the quantity can't be delivered. The price of the lotus flower, which usually sells for Rs 8 a dozen, has now risen to Rs 30 with exports for pujas overseas also eating into the demand. This Puja could end up lotus-less. A reflection of national politics, perchance? *by Abhijit Dasgupta*

BANGALORE |

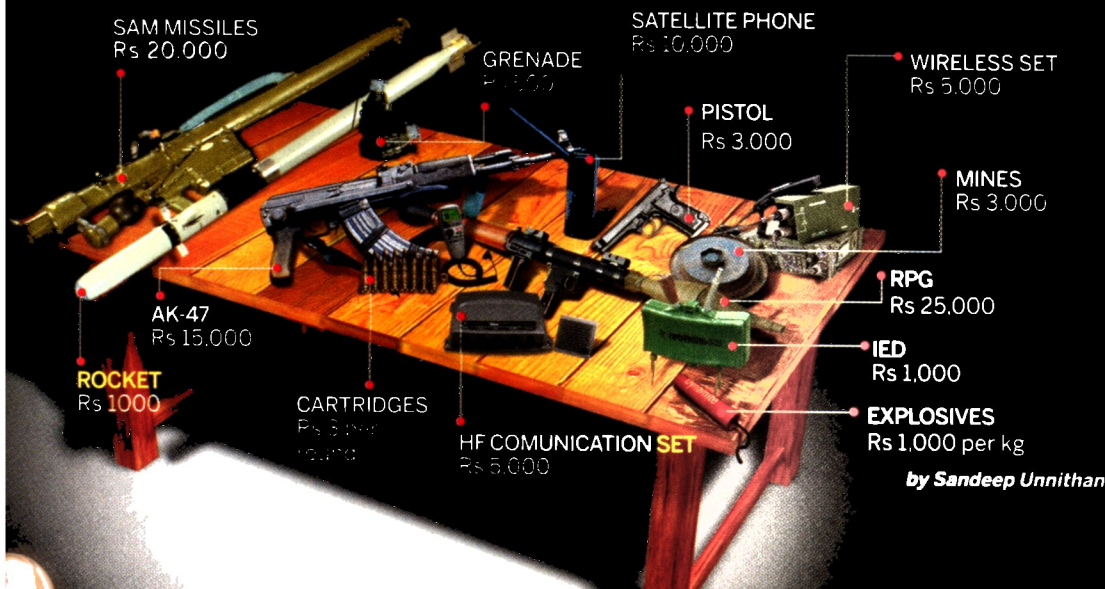
It's a Deal

While Indian agencies were trying to counter news of a Chinese incursion into Ladakh, Karnataka Chief Minister B.S. Yeddyurappa was busy attracting investments there. With an idea to invite business leaders for the Global Investors' Meet at Bangalore in January 2010, he told investors in Shanghai and Beijing that his Government plans to free up to 50,000 acres for industries and release a new information policy to be in sync with the current business environment.

by Stephen David

DELHI | Bargain Price

The Home Ministry has announced cash incentives to Maoists surrendering weapons that range from Rs 3 per bullet to Rs 20,000 for a surface-to-air missile. It's a varied price list.



by Sandeep Unnithan

GRAPHIC BY PRASHANT CHAUDHRY